



HUMANITAS  
INSTITUTE

## Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Saint Raphael Catholic School

School Website: <https://school.saintraphaelcrystal.org/>

January 7, 2026

**Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer**

*This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.*

## Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

### Executive Summary

Saint Raphael Catholic School (Crystal, MN 55428) presents a strongly classical Catholic program across its public materials. The school identifies itself explicitly as a Catholic, classical institution focused on formation in virtue, wisdom, and the love of truth, goodness, and beauty. Public materials emphasize a Trivium-centered curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric), a liberal-arts orientation, and a family-centered partnership with parents. Religion instruction is integrated with the Magisterium and sacramental practice, and the school highlights liturgical life, catechesis, and the sacramental life as core to formation. The faculty pages and mission statements frame teachers as living exemplars and part of a “living curriculum,” with clear attention to character formation and a collaborative community with parents. Overall, the school aligns with the six classical-element criteria as CLASSICAL, with strong signals in religious/metaphysical foundations, purpose and goals, curriculum, pedagogy, faculty, and parent/community engagement.

Key evidentiary signals include: the mission to form students in a faithfully Catholic education and to cultivate truth, beauty, and goodness; explicit references to the Magisterium and CGS in religion; a Core Content that foregrounds the Mass, liturgy, sacraments, and virtue; detailed articulation of the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and classical curriculum; lower- and upper-school pedagogy featuring contemplative and Socratic/seminar-based approaches; faculty described as living exemplars and part of a living curriculum; and an emphasis on parents as primary educators and on family partnership. See sources describing mission and Catholic/ liturgical formation, the Core Content religion program, classical curriculum and Trivium, and parent-community collaboration.

Note: The analysis below uses a keyword-based rubric drawn from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) and its associated lexicon, cross-checked against the public-facing content of the Saint Raphael site. Positive keyword indicators (e.g., truth, virtue, wisdom, liturgy, great books, Trivium, formation) are used to gauge alignment; negative indicators (e.g., secularism, values-neutrality, project-based dominance without classical grounding) are checked where present. The school’s materials show strong presence of positive classical indicators with minimal signals of negative indicators in the public materials reviewed.

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### Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

#### Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials frame the school as “Catholic classical” and emphasize fidelity to Catholic doctrine and liturgy, including references to the Magisterium and catechesis. For example, religion is taught “in full accord with the Magisterium of the Catholic Church,” and catechesis (CGS) is described as part of preschool and kindergarten religion pedagogy. - The school highlights liturgical life, sacraments, and prayer as integral to formation, including Mass and liturgy, and the sacramental life. - The mission statement explicitly cites transcendental values of truth, beauty, and goodness as foundational to education.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive: truth, goodness, beauty, liturgy, Mass, liturgical life, Mass, catechesis, Magisterium, sacraments, sacred, imago Dei, theology (implicit in Catholic formation). The site frequently uses terms such as “transcendental values of truth, beauty and goodness” and “faithfully Catholic,” signaling robust positive alignment with religious metaphysical foundations. Approximate positive

keyword hits include: truth, beauty, goodness, transcendentals, liturgy, Mass, sacraments, Magisterium, catechesis, sacred, theology. Negative indicators: none apparent in the public materials reviewed. - Why this rating: The school's own framing—explicit Catholic identity, liturgical life, sacramental education, and the Magisterium-based theology—maps directly to the classical-element criterion for a grounded religious/meta-physical orientation.

Citations: Catholic/Catholic-family framing, Magisterium, CGS, liturgy, sacraments, and transcendental values are evidenced in the Saint Raphael materials cited above.

## Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents a formation-focused purpose: "Our mission is to cultivate a family-centered community that classically forms students in a faithfully Catholic education, bringing forth joyful witnesses to the love of Jesus Christ." This frames virtue and formation as the aim of education rather than mere job preparation. - The public content stresses truth, beauty, and goodness as guiding transcendental aims, and cites formation of character, virtue, and wisdom as central outcomes. The core language emphasizes formation over mere information and a philosophical orientation toward higher goods. - Classical pedagogy language appears in mission/style—"classically forms students," "love of wisdom and personal formation," and explicit reference to a Western classical tradition.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive: formation, virtue, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, human flourishing, moral imagination, contemplation, lifelong learning, great conversation (the Great Conversation language appears in classical framing and is echoed in the public materials through explicit emphasis on classical formation). The materials show multiple references to formation and the classical mission. Approximate positive keyword hits: formation, virtue, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, contemplation, great conversation (conceptual), sacred tradition, imago Dei, Logos. - Negative: none evident; the materials strongly reject a purely utilitarian or secular framing. - Why this rating: The school's stated purpose aligns with classical paideia aims: formation toward virtue and wisdom, with transcendental ideals guiding education.

Citations: Mission and formation language; transcendental values; and formation emphasis are evidenced in the cited mission and core content materials.

## Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Liberal arts core is explicitly described in public materials as classical, with emphasis on grammar, logic, and rhetoric. The site highlights a classical curriculum and a focus on the liberal arts, history, and the classics. - The Trivium is presented as the framework for instruction (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric), with references to memorization, historical study, and classical literature. The public materials discuss the School's focus on classical texts and logic, rhetoric, and a Western-tradition-based curriculum. - There are explicit mentions of a history-centric curriculum and a reading/engagement with classic texts, including middle/high-school literature that emphasizes classic works. The materials describe Sacred history and Western traditions as foundational, and reference the "great books/classical texts" approach in spirit if not always with the exact phrase "Great Books."

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive: grammar, logic, rhetoric, classical, liberal arts, great books (conceptually present through "classical texts" and "great conversation" framing), history (as a classical discipline rather than social studies), wonder, and a global classical canon. Approximate positive keyword hits: grammar, logic, rhetoric, classical, liberal arts, history (as classical history), great books (conceptually referenced), wonder. - Negative: Montessori in preschool is not inherently negative for a classical assessment, but it is a non-classical pedagogy signal at the earliest stage. If measured strictly, Montessori could be viewed as a potential non-classical element in a pure K–8 classical curriculum, but the site's overall classical framing and subsequent Trivium emphasis outweigh this at the public level. Positive-to-negative balance remains strongly favorable for CLASSICAL in this category. - Why this rating: The curriculum is squarely grounded in classical pedagogy, with explicit references to grammar/logic/rhetoric, a Trivium-centered ap-

proach, and emphasis on liberal arts and history. The Montessori element is limited to preschool and does not undermine the overall classification.

Citations: Classical curriculum language, Trivium emphasis, and classic-text orientation are evidenced in core curriculum pages.

#### **Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL**

Evidence - The site describes both contemplative/restful elements and rigorous inquiry, including slower, memory-building routines (e.g., “memory work,” recitation, singing in lower grades) and more Socratic/seminar discussions in upper grades. This aligns with the classic scholé (restful study) approach coupled with Socratic pedagogy. - Lower-school pedagogy includes singing, chanting, and memory work; upper grades emphasize Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and rhetorical training (speeches). The public materials explicitly mention these modalities. - The public materials describe the upper school as training in rhetoric and giving speeches, consistent with classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive: contemplative/restful learning (scholé), memorization/recitation, chanting, singing, memory work, Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, rhetoric, public speaking, masterful discourse, and living-books-inspired pedagogy (as reflected in “classical education” language). Positive keyword hits include: scholé, memorization, recitation, singing/chanting, Socratic, seminars, debates, rhetoric, public speaking. Approximate hits: 7–8. - Negative: the lexicon’s negative indicator for Pedagogy would flag an over-emphasis on project-based learning (experiential learning) or purely student-directed approaches if present as dominant; the Saint Raphael materials show a balanced mixture rather than an exclusively project-based approach. No explicit project-based dominance is described in public materials. - Why this rating: The teaching methods align with classical pedagogy across lower-to-upper grades, balancing memory work and contemplation with Socratic discussion and rhetoric instruction.

Citations: Pedagogy signals are evidenced in core content (religion pedagogy and classical curriculum), upper-school Socratic/seminar language, and lower-school memory/chanting practices.

#### **Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL**

Evidence - The Faculty pages and staff directories highlight teachers as core contributors and models for students, consistent with the classical “living curriculum” notion and portrait of teachers as exemplars. The materials describe teachers as mentors and “living curriculum,” and public pages show profiles of teachers. - The About sections emphasize teachers who model virtue and a culture of excellence, aligning with the classical ideal of a teacher as a virtuous exemplar and guide. The school describes teachers conveying transcendental values through daily practice and a shared mission.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive: living curriculum, model teachers, mentors, portrait of teacher, collegial culture, teachers as exemplars, virtue modeling, intellectual formation. Positive keyword hits include: living curriculum, mentor, teacher as model, portrait, collegiality, virtue formation. - Negative: none evident in the public materials; no clear signals of a discounting of teacher formation or de-emphasizing the teacher as moral exemplar. - Why this rating: The school consistently presents faculty as central, virtuous guides who form students and embody the curriculum.

Citations: Faculty-related language and staff pages are cited in the materials.

#### **Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL**

Evidence - The public materials emphasize partnership with families and the role of parents as primary educators, aligning with classical expectations of family involvement in formation. The “About Saint Raphael” page foregrounds parental partnership and family-centered culture. - The school notes that parents are the primary educators and that the school’s mission unfolds in partnership with parents; there is a focus on open communication and community activities that involve families. The Parent-Student Handbook and

tuition materials also reflect ongoing parent engagement and community life. - The school advertises open visits and family participation in events and community life (e.g., open houses, family activities).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive: partnership with families, parents as co-educators, family-centered community, parental formation (book groups, gatherings implied), open campus/visits. Positive keyword hits include: partnership with families, parent as co-educator, family involvement, parental formation, home-school collaboration, community events. - Negative: none evident in public materials; no signals of consumer-only parent relations or minimal parent involvement. - Why this rating: The public materials clearly present parents as essential collaborators in formation, consistent with the classical model of parent-school partnership.

Citations: About page language and parent-community language are cited.

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### **What Would Move the Needle**

- Not applicable since the school already scores CLASSICAL across all six categories. No category is ranked SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, so no needle-moving recommendations are required.
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## Appendix

### ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

### Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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